

Daydreaming

By Shiloh Sharmahd

This work is a visual take on an excerpt from *The Phantom Tollbooth* by Norton Juster. A kids chapter book that plays with words and language in abnormally hilarious ways. The particular passage I use is a quote from the Lethargarians, a group of beings who live in the Doldrums. A place where thinking is illegal among other things: thinking of thinking, surmising, presuming, reasoning, meditating, and speculating.

This piece is a lens to see text in a new way. Inspired by the Travesty Generator, in particular the Poem I Can't Breathe. Our work creates a new experience as words go through the system. You might come across new words and patterns in your text that you hadn't considered before. Say you input a phrase into the permutation program in the Travesty Generator, the computer generates a new, but deterministic way of visualizing the poem. Mine does something similar.

I liked making this project because I got to code and make it all clean. I like to keep my main game loops simple, clean, and readable. Just a few functions to read. To create the effect I made a Dial class that has a position and a target. Each frame the dial checks if its position is the target, if not it sets its position to slightly closer to the target. The position of a dial determines the characters displayed, for example at position 0, A is in the middle with B and C below, Above are ? and !. I make a dial for each letter of the longest word in the passage.

As for the aesthetic, I was originally inspired by the clock app on ios, it has rotating dials almost like a bike lock. I am *super* used to setting timers with them. Timers to sleep in for just 20 more minutes. Until I press it again. That's why the theme of this particular piece is procrastination. I even procrastinated making this project, this was supposed to be my project 1.

I find it fun to put other passages/texts into my program. Maybe I will make another version where the user can write and then hit play to watch their words transform. I had another idea for this project. I was super inspired by Alex's text editor toys and wanted to make one of my own. In mine, we would still have dials, typing would spell out the word with the dials, but there is no space character on the dials, when the user presses space, you don't see a change, but the next time you type a letter, the leftmost dial will move. Essentially giving the same visual as the original artwork, but the timing will be human made and its live writing. Maybe at the end the user can press a button to see the whole of their writing in a normal way.

In the Travesty Generator, there were completely unique poems made by an algorithm. That's in essence what I'm doing here, but there is a key difference, those were taking an input and creating a new output, a permutation of the input. My program literally changes the way you read. It leaves behind remnants of the previous, forgotten words, sometimes these remnants mean nothing, AAAAAAA. Sometimes they make an entirely new word, GOODMORNINGING. To my knowledge this is the first anybody has ever read this way. It is almost a challenge to decipher the original words out of the chaos.